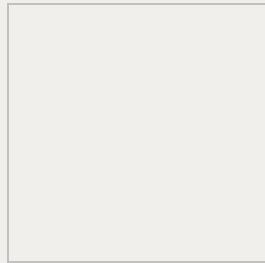


IN PROFILE

Ranieri de' Calzabigi

Orfeo's librettist Ranieri de' Calzabigi (1714–1795) was a picaresque figure in the mold of the Italian librettist Lorenzo da Ponte (1749–1838): an opportunistic adventurer and, in Casanova's judgment, "a great lover of women," who had fled Italy after a trial for murder. He was also a disciple of the French Enlightenment and an opponent of the vocal excesses of Italian opera. His ideas chimed perfectly with Gluck's. Calzabigi took the archetypal myth of Orpheus's descent to Hades to rescue Eurydice and pared it down to essentials. Gluck's music was correspondingly strong, direct and simple, shorn of Rococo frills and fripperies.



RANIERI DE'
CALZABIGI

Born in the small town of Erasbach, Bavaria, in 1714, Christoph Willibald Gluck was determined to become a musician, despite opposition from his father, who was a forester for the Bohemian nobility. At the age of 13, he ran away to Prague, surviving by singing and playing the Jew's harp.

In his early twenties, Gluck went via Vienna to Milan, where